

iQOO Z9 5G

A surprisingly good all-rounder

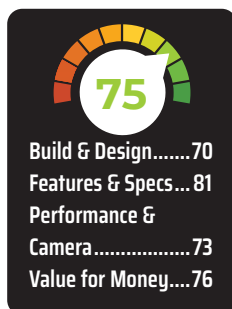
iQOO smartphones prioritise power above all – that’s the iQOO DNA we have become familiar with over the years. However, in the cutthroat smartphone market of 2024, that’s simply not enough. A focus on camera quality, battery life, and display is nearly essential. To that end, iQOO has taken it upon themselves to offer more holistic options across various budgets. The iQOO Z9 embodies this reform. While it boasts the fastest chipset under ₹20,000, it also features a robust camera system, a larger battery, and an improved display compared to its predecessor. The sub-₹20K price segment is extremely competitive, with rivals such as the Realme 12+ 5G, Motorola G84, and others. Let’s see if the iQOO Z9 can carve out a space for itself in the competitive budget smartphone market in my review.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The iQOO Z9 is well-built. It has the essentials such as an IP54 dust and water resistance rating, a matte back panel and a matte frame that resists fingerprints, and a super slim profile at just 7.83 mm thickness. It’s decently comfortable to hold and non-slippery as well, so you may actually get away with not using a case. However, the flat sides may dig into your palms at times.

The frame and rear panel are plastic, and this is where the iQOO Z9 falls behind. Competitors such as the Moto G84 and Realme 12+ 5G come with a sweet vegan leather back panel, which looks infinitely more premium.

The iQOO Z9 is available in two colourways – Brushed Green and Graphene Blue. I got the former for review. It has a feather-like pattern on the back that shows up when light reflects on it. The design could be considered as garish by



some, while some may like it; so it comes down to your personal preference.

The camera module is situated on the top left of the rear panel; it is a glossy black module that houses two cameras, the dual flash, and some text that reads “Aspherical Premium Lens”.

The iQOO branding sits on the bottom. The right side of the frame houses the power button and volume rocker while the left is completely blank. On the bottom, you have the USB-C charging port, one of the two speakers, and a SIM/SD card tray.

Up front, the bezels are pretty slim on three sides, but the chin is considerably thicker. The iQOO Z9 houses an in-display fingerprint sensor, but it is not the fastest I’ve experienced at this price. All in all, I like the build quality of the iQOO Z9; it uses plastic but doesn’t feel very cheap. However, the vegan leather backs cropping up in the sub-₹20,000 segment pose serious competition to the iQOO Z9 in this regard.

DISPLAY

Last year, the iQOO Z7 boasted a display measuring just 6.38 inches – a rarity in the budget segment where compact phones have nearly disappeared. It’s sad news for compact phone lovers as the iQOO Z9 ditches the compact form factor and adopts a more traditional 6.67-inch display size. So, this year you get a 6.67-inch AMOLED display with Full HD+ resolution and 120 Hz refresh rate support. The phone has Adaptive Refresh Rate support as well, but weirdly enough, the phone doesn’t support 120 Hz scrolling in any app I tried including YouTube, Snapchat, and even Chrome. The only time it stays at 120 Hz is when you’re scrolling through the phone’s UI, which is quite disappointing.

Refresh rate issues aside, the display is quite impressive given the affordable price tag. It has 394 PPI, meaning it is sharp enough. The display also supports 16.7 million colours and is HDR-compliant. When I watched HDR content on YouTube and Netflix, everything looked crisp and vibrant. The AMOLED display produces deep blacks and enhanced contrast. The phone is also sufficiently bright. It is rated at 1,800 nits of peak local brightness, and in my tests, I got a reading of over 1,300 nits in Auto Brightness Mode under bright sunlight.

The dual stereo speakers enhance the content consumption experience; it is a huge leap over the single speaker that was present in its predecessor, the iQOO Z7. The speaker produces full sound with good bass and vocals.

PERFORMANCE

Everyone expects iQOO to top the performance charts and the iQOO Z9 successfully does that in the sub-₹20,000 price segment. It features the powerful MediaTek Dimensity 7200 chipset which has a maximum clock speed of 2.8 GHz. It has 8 GB of LPDDR4X RAM and up to 256 GB of UFS 2.2 storage, with the option to expand it via SD card. The UFS 2.2 storage speeds are slower compared to the newly launched Realme 12+, which has UFS 3.1.

That aside, the iQOO Z9 pretty much destroys every other phone under